as the protean prejudice against Jews amounts to a kind of metaphysical psychosis. There is, however, another strange aspect which deserves further inspection. This is that hostility towards Israel is so much against the west's own self-interest. Even more striking is that this is part of a systematic pattern of self-destructive western activity.

In Britain, which serves as the epicentre of this western animus, popular misconceptions and prejudices are significantly enhanced by the hostility towards Israel expressed by a political class which simultaneously professes to have Israel's interests at heart. The British Foreign Office insists, for example, that Israel's "occupation" of the disputed territories and settlement construction are illegal. This misrepresents both the Geneva conventions and the unabrogated treaty obligations of the Mandate for Palestine (from which Britain itself reneged) to settle the Jews in what is now Israel, Judea and Samaria, and Gaza. The UK played a key role in getting the EU suddenly to label, and thus potentially effect a boycott of, produce from the disputed territories. Despite David Cameron's early and strikingly unambiguous support for Israel at the start of Operation Protective Edge, his government soon slid into joining the popular clamour against civilian casualties whose numbers were grossly inflated by Hamas. And it wasn't until the following year's attack on a kosher supermarket in Paris that the UK government started expressing its concern over the shocking outbreak of anti-Isreal and anti-Jewish attacks in Britain.

In the United States, the Obama administration has displayed repeated hostility and even malice towards Israel. It has blamed Israel quite unjustly for scuppering the peace process, while giving the Palestinian Authority a free pass for doing precisely that. Both President Obama and Secretary of State John Kerry have issued threats that Israel risks being left friendless in the world if it doesn't cave into the PA's demands, ignoring its routine incitement to hatred and the murder of Jews.

Yet Israel is vital to the security interests of the United States, UK, and the rest of the west. Despite the fact that the British and American governments try to tie Israel's hands when it seeks to defend its citizens against mass murder, the British and American intelligence services and military establishment work closely with Israel. Understanding that Israel's fight is also their own fight against Islamic terrorism, they want and need Israeli information, military expertise, and kit. Israel is the west's defence outpost in the Middle East and its sole reliable ally in the region. So what sense does it make to reward and incentivise those waging existential war against Israel when this is so much against western interests?

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